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School district decries 'anti-Semitic' proposal

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Recently the Las Virgenes Unified School District Board of Education unanimously approved a resolution to denounce not only California's new Ethnic Studies Model Curriculum content, but also the method by which the state was allowed to bring forward such a deeply flawed proposal.

The ethnic studies draft fails to comply with its primary mission to "include accurate information based on current and confirmed research to . . . promote critical thinking and rigorous analysis of history, systems of oppression, and the status quo in an effort to generate discussions on futurity, and imagine new possibilities."

Rather than uphold the virtues it was entrusted to advance, the state shrouds its entire approach to diversity in a dangerous cloak of ideological extremism and systemic anti-Semitism bent on erasing the Jewish experience from education.

Throughout hundreds of pages of proposed guidelines, the state's silence on anti-Semitism is deafening and serves to marginalize the American Jewish/California Jewish experience.

As if silence was not bad enough, the proposal offers sole condemnation for Israel in biased and inaccurate statements that outright support the Boycott, Divest and Sanctions (BDS) Movement, which has widely been condemned as a hate movement adhering to anti-Semitic themes, such as Jewish subversion, conspiracy, disloyalty, greed and economic control.

The proposed curriculum even recommends the "educational" use of racist song lyrics promoting these classic anti-Semitic tropes.

This dangerous slant extends beyond intentional exclusions for marginalized groups of our population. The state panel attempts to further indoctrinate extreme biased views with definitions of "capitalism" and "intellectualism" as being comparable to the oppressiveness of "racism" and "white supremacy."

It is hard to believe that in California in 2019, at a time when the ugly face of anti-Semitism is once again on the march, our state would give any cover or cede any ground to the ignorant ideologies that flow forth from this proposal.

We cannot allow the darker elements of our society that have long remained in the shadows to now step forth into the light and contaminate the next generation of youth with their narrow and corrupt ideologies.

As Nobel Laureate and Holocaust survivor Elie Weisel said, "There may be times when we are powerless to prevent injustice, but there must never be a time when we fail to protest."

We strongly encourage our entire community to join with our local leaders state Sen. Henry Stern and Assemblymembers Jesse Gabriel and Richard Bloom to protest not only this proposed curriculum but to demand a full review of the systems and processes that enabled such a flawed and biased outcome to unfold unchecked.

Mathy Wasserman and Dallas Lawrence are members of the LVUSD Board of Education.

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